

Benoni, Benko and Old Indian

Space, queenside restraint, and the discipline to neutralize compensation

THE PROMISE

Keep the d5 space wedge, meet Black's pawn breaks before they become activity, and convert an extra pawn only after the position is under control.

COURSE VOLUME 08 OF 10

SEE THE POSITION | RECALL THE PLAN | CALCULATE THE MOVE

What this volume should change

- Use the Bf4/h3/e3 system against the Modern Benoni.
- Meet ...b5 with structural understanding rather than reflexive acceptance or refusal.
- Accept the Benko Gambit and neutralize files before trying to cash the extra pawn.
- Handle Old Indian, Czech Benoni, and direct 1...c5 move orders.

STUDY METHOD

Learn each chapter in three layers: first the trigger and plan, then the short main line, then Black's branches. Hide the page and reconstruct the line on a board. Do not memorize notation without the position's purpose.

Inside this volume

01	Modern Benoni spine
02	The ...b5 break
03	The e5 break and central expansion
04	Benko Gambit accepted
05	Benko bishop recapture and king placement
06	Old Indian Defense
07	Czech Benoni closed center
08	Direct 1...c5 and rare Benoni orders

Original instructional synthesis. Move sequences were legality-checked with python-chess and critical choices were reviewed with Stockfish 18. Opening-frequency context was checked against the Lichess opening explorer in September 2026. Engines verify tactics; the explanations and training design are the course's teaching layer. Diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork as distributed by Lichess under GPLv2+.

CHAPTER 01

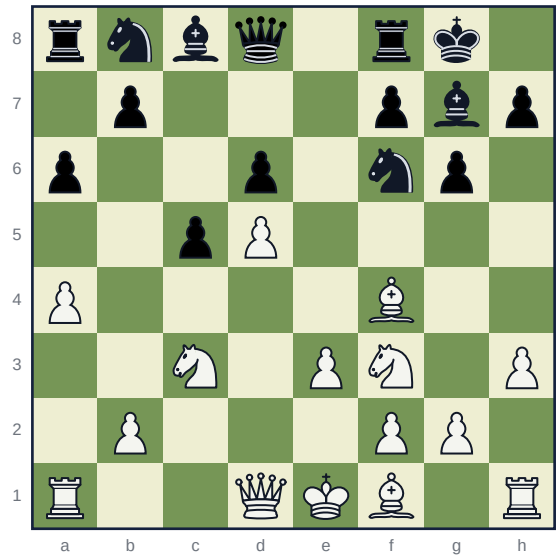
Modern Benoni spine

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6: Black attacks the space wedge.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nf3 g6 7. Bf4 a6 8. a4 Bg7 9. h3 O-O 10. e3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White builds the d5/e4 space structure with pieces ready to support it. Bf4 pressures d6, a4 restrains ...b5, and h3 prevents ...Bg4 from exchanging a key defender. e3 develops the light bishop and keeps the center compact. Black has active breaks on ...b5 and ...f5, so White's space must be converted through development, not defended passively.

White's plan

- Use a4 to slow ...b5 and Bf4 to make d6 a lasting concern.
- Develop e3, Be2, and O-O; route Nd2-c4 when d6/c4 become strong squares.
- Prepare e4-e5 only when it opens lines favorably and creates a supported passed d-pawn.

What Black is trying to do

- ...b5 is Black's main queenside break and source of open files.
- ...f5 attacks e4 and may open the f-file against White's king.
- ...Bg4 and ...Bf5 can exchange defenders and reduce White's control of e4/d5.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...e6	4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5; preserve the space wedge.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...g6	7.Bf4 pressures d6 before e3.
7...a6	8.a4 directly restrains ...b5.
...Bg7	h3 and e3; complete development before central expansion.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Space is temporary unless pieces use it. Do not spend every move protecting d5; develop toward e5, c4, and the queenside files.

MEMORY HOOK

Bf4 hits d6, a4 stops ...b5, h3 preserves the knight, e3 completes the shell.

CHAPTER 02

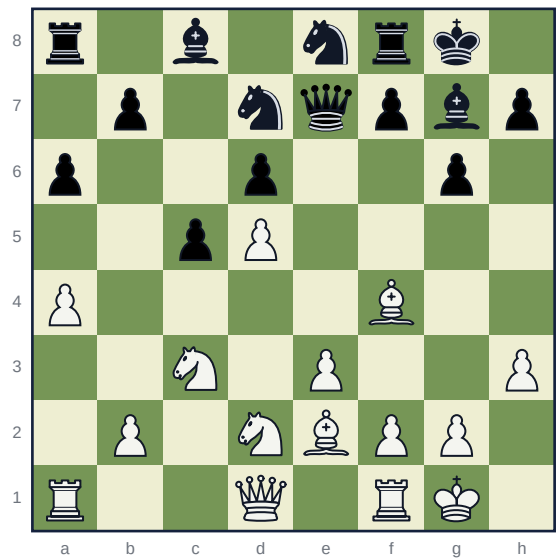
The ...b5 break

POSITION TRIGGER

Black has prepared ...b5 despite White's a4 restraint or through a tactical move order.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nf3 g6 7. Bf4 a6 8. a4 Bg7 9. h3 O-O 10. e3 Qe7 11. Be2 Nbd7 12. O-O Ne8 13. Nd2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Black reroutes ...Ne8 to support ...g5 or ...f5 and may still force ...b5 with ...Rb8. Nd2 heads to c4, where it pressures d6 and b6. If ...b5 arrives, axb5 can open the a-file and leave a6 weak, while cxb5 may create a passed c-pawn for Black. Choose the capture by the resulting files, not by habit.

White's plan

- Place Nd2-c4 before opening the queenside so d6 remains under pressure.
- Against ...b5, compare axb5 and cxb5 by which file opens and which passed pawn appears.
- Use Bf3 or Re1 to support e5 if Black's pieces migrate to the queenside.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Rb8 and ...b5 sacrifice or exchange a pawn to activate rooks and bishops.
- ...Ne8-c7 supports b5 and defends d5/b5 squares.
- ...f5 may strike the center while White concentrates on queenside restraint.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...Rb8	Nd2-c4 and a5 may clamp b6/b5.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...b5	Calculate axb5 first; open a-file pressure may make the break a concession.
...Ne8	Nd2-c4 improves the knight while Black reroutes.
...f5	Use exf5 or e5 only after checking whether the g7 bishop becomes stronger.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Preventing ...b5 forever is not always possible. The practical goal is to make the break create a weakness or cost Black enough time.

MEMORY HOOK

Restrain, improve Nd2-c4, then meet ...b5 by the files it creates.

CHAPTER 03

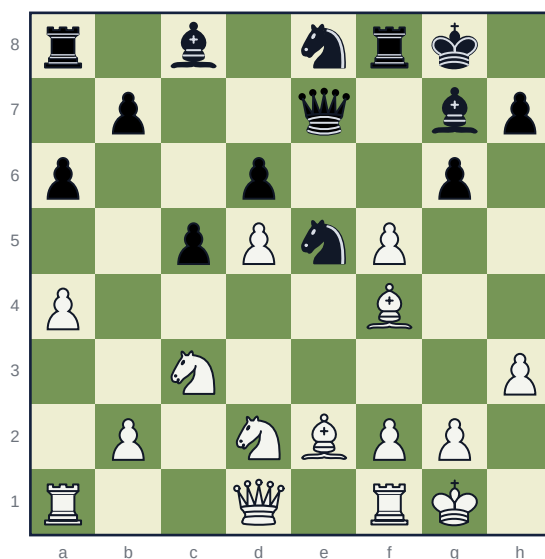
The e5 break and central expansion

POSITION TRIGGER

White is developed and Black's queenside break is controlled; the center can advance.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nf3 g6 7. Bf4 a6 8. a4 Bg7 9. h3 O-O 10. e3 Qe7 11. Be2 Nbd7 12. O-O Ne8 13. Nd2 f5 14. e4 Ne5 15. exf5



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White's e-pawn can exchange on f5 or advance e4-e5 depending on development and Black's piece placement. exf5 opens the e-file and may leave Black with a weak e6/d6 complex; e5 gains space but can be attacked by ...Nxe5 or ...dxe5 tactics. The decision should create a passed pawn, an open line, or a superior square - not merely gain one rank.

White's plan

- Use exf5 when the open e-file and pressure on e6/d6 favor White.
- Use e5 when the d-pawn becomes passed and Black cannot blockade it securely.
- Coordinate Re1, Qd2/Qc2, and Nc4 before opening lines.

What Black is trying to do

- ...f5 challenges e4 and opens the f-file.
- ...Ne5 blockades the center and attacks c4/f3.
- ...Nbd7-e5 can trade White's active pieces and leave d5 isolated.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...f5	Compare exf5 with e5; choose by piece activity after the pawn exchange.
...Ne5	Nxe5 or Bxe5 only when the resulting d-pawn remains strong.
...Qe7	Re1 and Nd2-c4; align pieces before opening.
...Nh5	Bxd6 or Bg3 according to whether preserving d6 pressure matters.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

A space pawn that advances too soon can lose its defenders and become a blockade target. Prepare the break with pieces first.

MEMORY HOOK

Break only when it creates a file, passed pawn, or permanent square.

CHAPTER 04

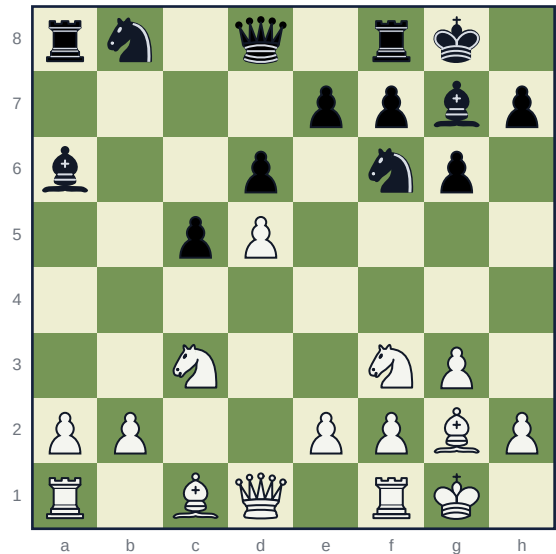
Benko Gambit accepted

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 b5: Black offers a queenside pawn for files and long-term pressure.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. bxa6 Bxa6 6. Nc3 d6 7. Nf3 g6 8. g3 Bg7 9. Bg2 O-O 10. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White accepts the pawn and immediately builds a fianchetto shell to contest the long diagonal. The extra a-pawn is not a winning advantage by itself; Black receives a- and b-file pressure, active bishops, and easy development. White's first objective is neutralization: secure b2, control b4/c5, trade an active rook or bishop, and only then use the extra pawn or central space.

White's plan

- Fianchetto g3/Bg2 and castle to contest the g7 bishop.
- Use Rb1, Qc2, and Nd2-c4 to defend b2 and challenge d6.
- Trade one pair of rooks or Black's dark bishop when possible; compensation falls with active pieces.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Ra7-b7 and ...Qa5 create heavy pressure on b2.
- ...Nbd7-b6/c5 brings pieces to queenside entry squares.
- ...e6 attacks d5 and may open the g7 bishop through the center.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...b5	4.cxb5 accepts the gambit.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...a6	5.bxa6. Take the second pawn only because the course knows how to neutralize the files.
5...Bxa6	6.Nc3 d6 7.Nf3 and fianchetto.
...g6	g3/Bg2/O-O; contest the long diagonal before expanding.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not try to 'prove' the extra pawn by holding every pawn. Return one if it exchanges Black's most active pieces or completes development.

MEMORY HOOK

Accept, fianchetto, neutralize files, then think about the extra pawn.

CHAPTER 05

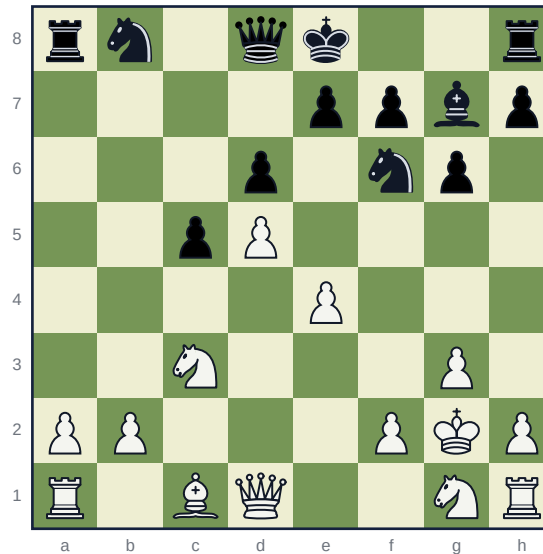
Benko bishop recapture and king placement

POSITION TRIGGER

Black recaptures a6 and offers an exchange on f1 that changes White's king position.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. bxa6 g6 6. Nc3 Bxa6 7. e4 Bxf1 8. Kxf1 d6 9. g3 Bg7 10. Kg2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White allows Bxf1 and uses Kxf1 because the center is closed enough for Kg2. In return, White keeps both central pawns and removes Black's active a6 bishop. The king route costs time, so White should avoid unnecessary pawn moves. Once Kg2 is reached, Nf3, h3, and Re1 complete coordination while Black attacks the queenside.

White's plan

- Use Kxf1-g2 to reach safety without weakening the dark squares further.
- Develop Nf3 and h3; use Re1 to support e4 and central breaks.
- Keep b2 defended and challenge Black's rooks before using the extra a-pawn potential.

What Black is trying to do

- ...d6 and ...Bg7 create pressure while White spends a tempo on Kg2.
- ...O-O and ...Nbd7 lead to quick queenside activation.
- ...Qa5 or ...Nbd7-b6 can exploit the unconnected rooks.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...g6	6.Nc3 Bxa6 7.e4 keeps the broad center.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...Bxf1	8.Kxf1. Accept the king route and remove Black's active bishop.
...d6	g3 and Kg2; finish king safety.
...Bg7	Nf3 and Re1; secure the center while watching b2.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

A king on g2 can be safe in a closed center, but the lost castling right makes tempi precious. Finish coordination before queenside adventures.

MEMORY HOOK

If Bxf1, use Kxf1-g2; trade the bishop, then reconnect the rooks.

CHAPTER 06

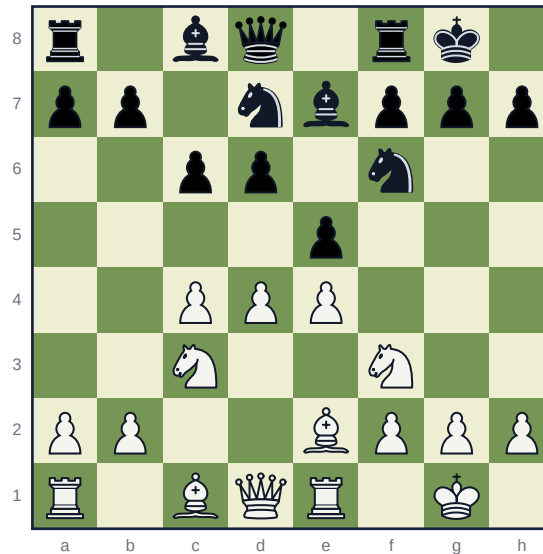
Old Indian Defense

POSITION TRIGGER

Black uses ...d6 and ...e5 without a kingside fianchetto.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 d6 3. Nc3 e5 4. Nf3 Nbd7 5. e4 Be7 6. Be2 O-O 7. O-O c6 8. Re1



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White builds the classical center and develops naturally. Black's bishop on e7 is less active than a King's Indian bishop on g7, so White can keep central tension longer. Re1 supports e4; Bf1 and Rb1/b4 may follow if the center closes. If Black exchanges exd4, Nxd4 centralizes the knight and White controls d5.

White's plan

- Develop Nf3, e4, Be2, and O-O; keep the center flexible.
- Use Re1/Bf1 against ...c6 and close d5 when queenside expansion becomes stable.
- Against ...exd4, recapture Nxd4 and control d5 before expanding.

What Black is trying to do

- ...c6 prepares ...d5 or supports a closed-center queenside defense.
- ...Re8 adds pressure to e4 and may prepare ...Bf8.
- ...exd4 opens lines and challenges White to prove the space advantage.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
2...d6	3.Nc3 e5 4.Nf3; build the center.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...Nbd7	5.e4 Be7 6.Be2 and castle.
...c6	Re1 and decide d5 from the queenside plan.
...exd4	Nxd4 and use the d5 outpost.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not assume the Old Indian is harmless. Black's compact position can strike with ...d5 if White spends too many tempi on the wings.

MEMORY HOOK

Build and castle; control ...d5; close only when the queenside plan is ready.

CHAPTER 07

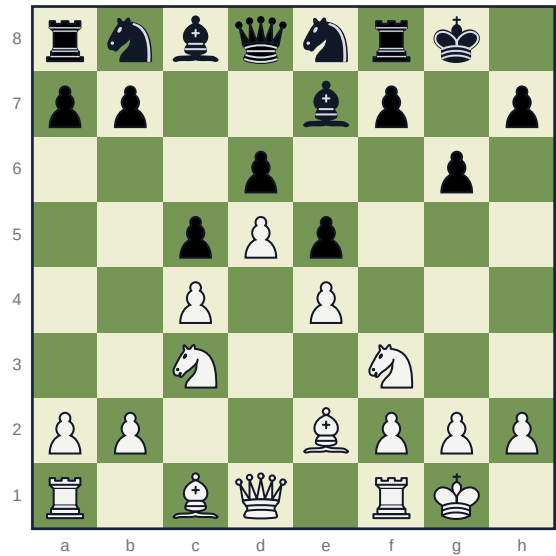
Czech Benoni closed center

POSITION TRIGGER

Black answers d5 with ...e5, locking the center without exchanging c- or e-pawns.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e5 4. Nc3 d6 5. e4 Be7 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be2 Ne8 8. O-O g6



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The center is closed and White has more space. The natural plan is queenside expansion with a3, Rb1, and b4; Black often prepares ...f5. White must decide whether exf5 opens the g-file/bishop or e5 gains space. Piece rerouting matters because direct central breaks are slow.

White's plan

- Use a3, Rb1, and b4 to open the queenside.
- Reroute Ne1-d3 or Nd2-c4 toward weak squares.
- Meet ...f5 based on which file opens and whether e5 becomes a stable passed pawn.

What Black is trying to do

- ...f5 attacks e4 and creates kingside play.
- ...g6 and ...Ng7 prepare ...f5 while keeping pieces behind the chain.
- ...a6 and ...b5 may contest the queenside before White opens it.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...e5	4.Nc3 d6 5.e4: take the space.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...Be7	Nf3, Be2, O-O; finish development before wing play.
...Ne8	a3/Rb1/b4; Black's knight signals ...f5.
...f5	Calculate exf5 versus e5; choose by files and piece routes.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Closed does not mean slow forever. Both sides prepare a wing break, so every preparatory move should improve the piece that will use the opened file.

MEMORY HOOK

Closed center: improve pieces toward b4/c4; watch ...f5.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
2...Nf6	3.Nc3 e6 4.e4 supports d5.
4...exd5	5.e5 gains time; calculate ...Qe7.
2...e6 without ...Nf6	Nc3 and e4; preserve the same broad center.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

This is the second major exception to automatic 2.c4. The first move ...c5 already asks d4 a question, and 2.d5 is the clearest answer.

MEMORY HOOK

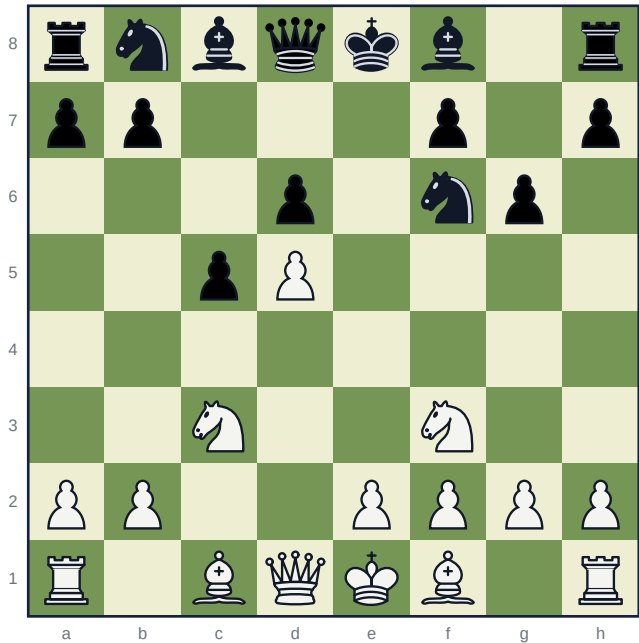
Against 1...c5: d5 first, then Nc3/e4, then develop after tactics.

Repertoire Test

For every position, name the opening branch, state your strategic objective, and choose a move. The answer is not only a move: it is a move attached to a reason.

TEST 01 | Benoni setup

Which three-move idea establishes this repertoire's positional shell?



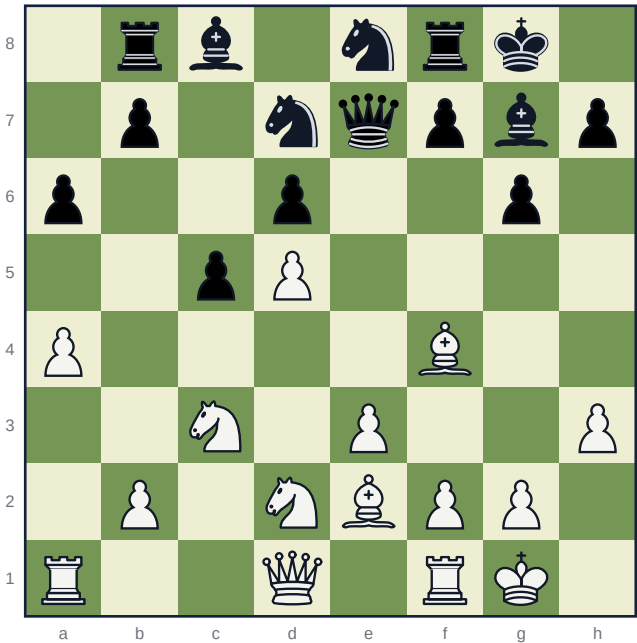
Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nf3 g6

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 02 | Meet the break

What improvement prepares White to meet ...b5?



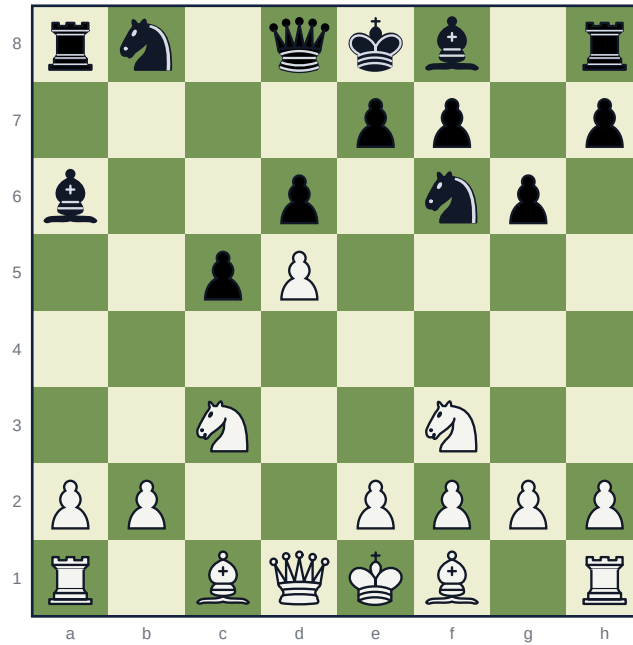
Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. Nf3 g6 7. Bf4 a6 8. a4 Bg7 9. h3 O-O 10. e3 Qe7 11. Be2 Nbd7 12. O-O Ne8 13. Nd2 Rb8

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 03 | Benko priority

What is White's first strategic objective after accepting the gambit?



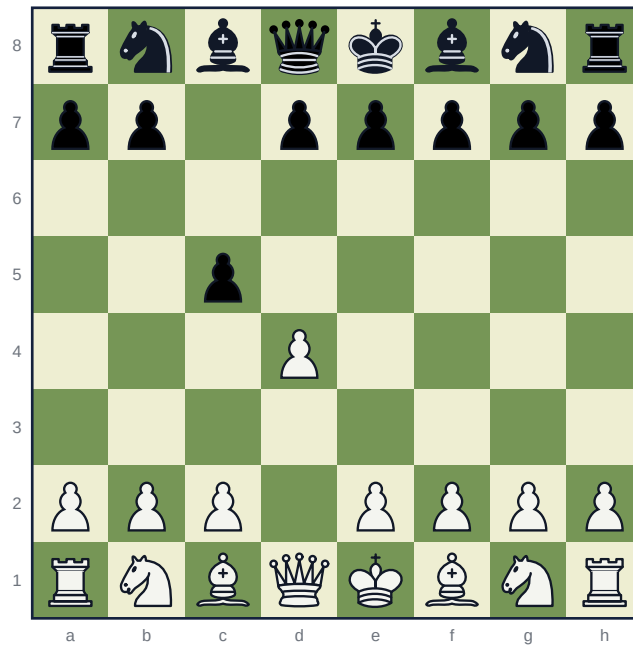
Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. bxa6 Bxa6 6. Nc3 d6 7. Nf3 g6

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 04 | First-move exception

Why does this course recommend 2.d5 rather than insisting on 2.c4?



Position reached by: 1. d4 c5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

Repertoire Test - Answers

TEST 01 | Benoni setup

Use 7.Bf4, then a4 and h3. Bf4 pressures d6, a4 restrains ...b5, and h3 prevents ...Bg4 from trading the f3 knight.

TEST 02 | Meet the break

Route the knight to c4. Nd2-c4 pressures d6 and b6. If ...b5 follows, evaluate axb5 by the opened a-file and the weakness of a6.

TEST 03 | Benko priority

Neutralize compensation with g3, Bg2, and O-O. Secure b2 and challenge Black's active rooks/bishop. The extra pawn matters only after the files are controlled.

TEST 04 | First-move exception

Black has already attacked d4. 2.d5 secures space and prepares Nc3/e4. The repertoire identity is central control with c4 where appropriate, not a mechanical second move.

One-Page Recall Card

Cover the right column. Read the trigger and say the memory hook. Then cover the left column and reconstruct which position produces that hook.

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6: Black attacks the space wedge.	Bf4 hits d6, a4 stops ...b5, h3 preserves the knight, e3 completes the shell.
Black has prepared ...b5 despite White's a4 restraint or through a tactical move order.	Restrain, improve Nd2-c4, then meet ...b5 by the files it creates.
White is developed and Black's queenside break is controlled; the center can advance.	Break only when it creates a file, passed pawn, or permanent square.
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 b5: Black offers a queenside pawn for files and long-term pressure.	Accept, fianchetto, neutralize files, then think about the extra pawn.
Black recaptures a6 and offers an exchange on f1 that changes White's king position.	If Bxf1, use Kxf1-g2; trade the bishop, then reconnect the rooks.
Black uses ...d6 and ...e5 without a kingside fianchetto.	Build and castle; control ...d5; close only when the queenside plan is ready.
Black answers d5 with ...e5, locking the center without exchanging c- or e-pawns.	Closed center: improve pieces toward b4/c4; watch ...f5.
Black challenges d4 before developing a knight: 1.d4 c5.	Against 1...c5: d5 first, then Nc3/e4, then develop after tactics.

SPACED REVIEW

Review today, tomorrow, after three days, after one week, and after one month. A chapter graduates only when you can reconstruct its anchor line and explain its plan without looking.

GAME TRANSFER

After every serious game, locate the first position where your memory ended. Study from that exact fork. This turns the repertoire into a living system while keeping the PDFs as the stable foundation.